



does Fritz have left in the legs," wondered John McEnroe. Not much, according to the oddsmakers who listed Sinner as a heavy -450 favourite and Fritz a +320 underdog.

"Let's be honest," said Patrick McEnroe. "It's going to take a perfect storm for Fritz to pull it off — great serving and the 24,000 fans will have to carry him through."

That 'perfect storm' never happened in the anticlimactic 6-3, 6-4, 7-5 final. The nervous Fritz made only 38 per cent of his first serves and lost his serve thrice in the opening set. Sinner, more confident and experienced in big matches, proved superior in every department, especially movement, stamina, and shot selection.

The crowd rewarded Fritz with a loud ovation when he put away a smash to edge ahead 15-30 on Sinner's serve. A forehand volley winner and a Sinner double fault gave Fritz his only break of serve in the third set and a short-lived 4-3

lead. Fritz's last best chance came when he served at 5-4, 30-30. But the relentlessly powerful Sinner forced a forehand error, and then Fritz dumped a forehand volley into the net to lose his serve.

When Fritz netted a forehand on championship point, coach Cahill wept and then hugged Simone Vagnozzi, his coaching partner. Sinner raised his arms in a low-key celebration.

"I think that [now] you can find yourself a little deeper in the draws — quarterfinals and stuff if you just play solid tennis. [But] I still think to beat the top players, you need to bring your best game," said Fritz.

"The good news for Taylor Fritz is that his average level is unbelievably high now," said *Tennis Channel* analyst Paul Annacone.

On the four leading Americans — Fritz, Tiafoe, Shelton, and Paul — Patrick McEnroe was cautiously optimistic. "They're close [to the top players], but they're pretty far still.

Big guns fail to fire: While Novak Djokovic was upset by a much-improved 28th-seed Alexei Popyrin in the third round, four-time major winner Carlos Alcaraz suffered a straight-sets loss to 74th-ranked Botic van de Zandschulp. *AFP*

They still have to improve a lot of little things in their games."

European men have won the last 59 Grand Slam singles titles, a streak that started in 2009 after 20-year-old Argentine Juan Martin del Potro upset Roger Federer in the US Open final.

Sinner became the first man to win his first two Major titles in the same year since Guillermo Vilas, another Argentine, in 1977, and Jimmy Connors captured three in 1974.

Looking forward, Patrick McEnroe said, "These two guys [Sinner and Alcaraz] are going to dominate the way the Big Three did."